Ironically, while Mamata spoke out openly against Modi, Jayalalithaa actually was one of the few state leaders who shared a special equation with the Gujarat chief minister. She had even attended his swearing-in as chief minister in 2012. But two years later, she wasn't willing to endorse Modi for prime minister. Instead, the AIADMK 'supremo' wanted to be the Supreme Leader herself, and her party had made a public declaration of the intent.

I asked Cho if he felt Jayalalithaa was really serious about moving to Delhi. 'I think she feels she has the capability to be the prime minister. And that Modi must also accept her leadership!' he said. My own understanding was that Jayalalithaa's prime ministerial ambition in this election was a smokescreen. Of course, she wanted to be prime minister, but she wasn't going to be a roadblock for Modi. She only wanted to tap into Tamil regional pride by playing the 'Jaya for PM' card. If she could maximize her seats in Tamil Nadu, then she would be a national player. The DMK had been in every central government since 1999 and had extracted a heavy price for their support. Jayalalithaa was hoping for a similar deal. If she could win thirty seats in Tamil Nadu, then in a hung Parliament she would have a decisive role to play in any ruling dispensation in Delhi. It was, therefore, a limited election strategy, not any long-term battle plan for the future.

Political expediency was guiding Mayawati as well. Like Jayalalithaa, she nurtures dreams of occupying 7, Race Course Road one day. But she probably knew that 2014 was not her moment. The BSP leader had been routed in the 2012 Uttar Pradesh assembly elections and hadn't fully recovered from the defeat. She was also tangled in a string of corruption cases that were still being heard in the Supreme Court. She needed to regroup and stay a little under the radar.

I had first met Mayawati around 1994. I had just moved to Delhi and had been researching the writings of Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar. Kanshi Ram, the founder of the BSP, was a great admirer of the Dalit icon. We'd spent many afternoons together sharing thoughts on Ambedkar's legacy. Dressed in a loose, white bush shirt, towel wrapped around his neck, and ill-fitting